

MAKING SMALL TALK AT WORK

SHOWCASES:
CEFR
CALIBRATION,
ACTIVITY DESIGN,
TEACHER
RESOURCE GUIDE

AT A GLANCE:

- ELT LESSON PLAN
 - ADULT LEARNERS
 - CEFR LEVEL A2
 - 60-MINUTE PRIVATE LESSON
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MATERIALS:

- STUDENT VERSION (5 PGS PDF)
 - TEACHER GUIDE (6 PGS PDF)
 - CREDITS AND ATTRIBUTIONS (1 PG PDF)
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OBJECTIVES:

BY THE END OF THIS LESSON, THE STUDENT WILL BE ABLE TO

- **FIGURE** OUT WHICH SMALL TALK TOPICS ARE FINE AT WORK AND WHICH ARE NOT
 - **RECALL** AND **USE** KEY VOCABULARY AND QUESTIONS FROM A SMALL TALK DIALOGUE BETWEEN TWO CO-WORKERS
 - **CREATE** A SMALL TALK DIALOGUE THAT INCLUDES THREE SUITABLE TOPICS AND A TRANSITION TO A MEETING.
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Making Small Talk at Work | ELT Worksheet

Student Version | CEFR Level: A2 | Adult Learners | 60-Minute Private Lesson

Objectives

By the end of this lesson, I'll be able to:

1. figure out which small talk topics are fine and not fine to use at work.
2. recall and use key vocabulary and questions from a small talk dialogue between two co-workers.
3. create a small talk dialogue that includes three suitable topics and a transition to a meeting.

Warm Up

Intro Questions

Answer the questions below to make them true for you. You can write or say your answer.



1. Do you like talking to your co-workers?

2. What do you talk to your co-workers about?

3. Is it always related to work, or do you talk about other things? _____

Listening: Small Talk Before a Meeting

Listen to this one-minute audio of two co-workers, Alice and Mark, having small talk before their team meeting. Think about these questions while listening:

1. What are three topics they talked about?
2. What did they say to 'transition' from having small talk to starting the meeting?

(Optional): Include your notes in the box below.

 [Click Here to Play Audio](#)



Reading: After listening to the audio, read the script below with your teacher.

Alice: Good morning, Mark. How are you?

Mark: I'm good, thanks, Alice. And you?

Alice: I'm fine. How was your weekend?

Mark: It was very nice. I went to the beach with my children. The weather was sunny and warm.

Alice: That sounds fun. Here it was rainy. So I stayed home and I made a cake.

Mark: A cake? That's a good idea for a rainy day.

Alice: Yes. My sister helped me. She has a new apartment now.

Mark: Oh, nice. Do you like it?

Alice: I like it a lot. My family is going there for the holiday next week.

Mark: That's great.

Alice: And you? What are your plans for the holiday?

Mark: I want to have a barbecue with my friends. But I need good weather.

Alice: I hope it's sunny for you. Okay. It's ten o'clock. Are we ready to start the meeting?

Mark: Yes. Everybody is here. Let's begin.



Now check your answers with the script.

Language Focus

Practice Task 1: Fine at Work or Better Not? *

Place each topic below into the 'Fine at Work' or 'Better not at Work' group.

**Religion | The weekend | Hobbies | Sports | Money problems | Plans for the holiday |
Medical issues | Movies | Politics | Family and friends**

Fine at Work	Better not at Work
1.	1.
2.	2.
3.	3.
4.	4.
5.	5.
6.	6.

What is one reason it may not be OK to talk about religion or politics at work? You can write or say your answer.

"I think it's not a good idea because _____."



*This can be different based on the country you live in or company you work for.

Practice Task 2: Useful Questions

Here are a few useful questions you can ask your colleague. Ask your teacher each question and listen to how they respond.

Useful Questions for Small Talk	Common Answers
How was your weekend?	
What are your plans for the holiday?	
Do you have any plans for the weekend?	



Time to switch roles! Your teacher will ask you these questions and you answer them.

Practice Task 3: Fill in the Blanks

Fill in the blanks based on the small talk between Mark and Alice. Try to remember the words, and if you need help, the script is on page #2.

Part 1 The weekend and the weather	Mark: I'm good, thanks, Alice. And you? Alice: I'm fine. How was your (1) _____? Mark: It was very nice. I went to the (2) _____ with my children. The (3) _____ was sunny and warm.
Part 2 Family	Alice: Yes. My (4) _____ helped me. She has a new apartment now. Mark: Oh, nice. Do you like it? Alice: I like it a lot. My (5) _____ is going there for the holiday next week.
Part 3 Plans for the holiday	Mark: That's great. Alice: And you? What are your plans for the (6) _____? Mark: I want to have a (7) _____ with my friends. But I need good weather.



Now try it again using your own real answers. Talk to your teacher about your actual weekend, family and/or holiday plans!

Practice Task 4: Finding the Transition

Do you remember how the small talk between Alice and Mark ended? What did they need to get ready for? Choose the best answers below to complete the dialogue.

- Alice:** Okay. It's ten o'clock. _____?
A) Time goes by so fast
B) We can start late
C) Are we ready to start the meeting?
- Mark:** Yes. Everybody is here. _____!
A) So, what do we do now?
B) Let's begin
C) What did you do this weekend Bob?



A **transition** is a sentence (or phrase) we use to move from one thing to another. In this example, from small talk to starting the meeting.

Can you think of two more examples of a transition?

1. _____ 2. _____

Your Turn

Create Your Own Small Talk!

You have 2 minutes to brainstorm and 5 minutes to create a small talk script between you and a colleague. Include **three of your favorite topics** to talk about, and **end with a phrase that transitions into a meeting**.

Once you're finished, share it with your teacher. You will do the role play together. Afterwards, your teacher will give you some feedback. Feel free to ask questions if you need help.

Brainstorm Notes (*hint: write down some of the key language and questions that we learned today*)



My Small Talk Script (*include at least 3 topics +1 transition phrase to a meeting*)

Making Small Talk at Work | ELT Worksheet

Teacher's Guide

CEFR Level: A2 | Adult Learners | 60-Minute Private Lesson

Lesson Section	Procedure	Scaffolding	Answers/Key Language	Rationale (optional)
Objectives	Ask student to read them.	Ask if they understand what dialogue and transitions mean.	—	Provide student with lesson roadmap
Warm-Up Engage Section 15 min				
Intro Questions	Ask student to read questions and answer in complete sentences.	Provide think time. If student is experiencing difficulties, begin sentences for them 'Yes, I like....' or, share your own examples 'I talk to my co-workers about many different things, especially my family.'	No right/wrong answers. Confirm what student shares is grammatically accurate and relative to the question.	Get S comfortable thinking about the topic and how it relates to them.
Listening - Small Talk Before a Meeting	Ask the student to read the instructions and pre-audio questions.	Optional: Encourage students to jot down their notes if this is something that will help the recall process later on.	All answers are acceptable: The weekend, family, baking, barbecue, weather, plans for the holiday <i>Alice:Okay. It's ten o'clock. Are we ready to</i>	The script not only provides student with a model example of small talk in the workplace, but will also be the foundation for the upcoming practice tasks in the 'Study' section of the lesson.

			<i>start the meeting?</i> Mark: Yes. Everybody is here. Let's begin.	
Play the Audio	Play once. Depending on whether this is a lesson delivered remotely or in a physical session, student may need to play audio on their side.	—	—	—
Read the script	Assign yourself and the student the role of Alice and Mark	If the student experiences issues pronouncing certain words, mark in your notes and save for after the script in lieu of preventing their reading flow.	—	Provides student another opportunity to answer the questions.
Now Check your answers with the script	Provide student a chance to respond to the questions verbally or in the written form.	If student is experiencing difficulties formulating a complete sentence, provide a model example and/or begin with the first few words (i.e. Mark	—	—

		and Alice talked about....)		
Language Focus Study Section 30 min				
Practice Task 1: Fine at Work or Better Not?	Student is expected to place the 10 different topics in one of the two categories.	If stuck, give one example from each category first.	Fine at work: The weekend, hobbies, sports, plans for the holiday, movies, family and friends Not fine: religion, money problems, medical issues, politics	Note: "why" question is a B1 stretch which is why the sentence stem has been included. Please emphasize that there are also cultural influences behind what's OK and not OK to discuss in the workplace. Objective focus: figure out which small talk topics are fine and not fine to use at work.
Practice Task 2: Useful Questions	Student asks you one question at a time. Respond naturally, trying to integrate a few of the key terms where possible.	—	No 'right' answer, but here are examples: 1. My weekend was great! I spent time with my family. We watched a really funny movie. 2. I plan on visiting my best friend during the holidays. 3. This weekend, I'm going to the	Student is now equipped with key language and phrases to begin building their own dialogue. Next task will allow them to put the pieces together before activating this knowledge in the 3rd section of the lesson. Objective focus: recall and use key vocabulary and questions from a small talk dialogue between two co-workers.

			park to play basketball.	
Practice Task 3: Fill-in-blanks	Encourage the student to complete the dialogue between Mark and Alice from memory.	If student is having difficulty recalling the information, they can use the script on page #2 as an aid.	(1) weekend (2) beach (3) weather (4) sister (5) family (6) holiday (7) barbecue	Objective focus: recall and use key vocabulary and questions from a small talk dialogue between two co-workers.
Practice Task 4: Finding the Transition	Student is expected to select the best option to complete the transition dialogue.	If student is having difficulties, they can quickly review the script on page #2.	1.-C- Are we ready to start the meeting 2.-B- Let's begin	Last activity that bridges to the activate section.
Your Turn Activate 15 minutes				
Create Your Own Small Talk!	Student is instructed to create a small talk between two colleagues. Here's the breakdown of the task + ideal time allotment: A. Brainstorm (2 minutes) B. Write dialogue (5 min) C. Read through the 1st draft of the	If student seems to be struggling with the brainstorming process, remind them about 1-2 topics that they used throughout the lesson.	No wrong or right answer for this section. It's the student's time to experiment with putting the pieces of the language they've learned into their own context.	Confirm the dialogue includes at least three suitable topics and one transition phrase before moving to feedback. If missing, prompt the student to retrieve the language from the applicable practice task. Objective focus: create a small talk dialogue that includes three suitable topics and a transition to a meeting.

	dialogue with the student without feedback (2 min) D. Provide the student with 2 positive comments and 2 errors-corrections. Engage the student by prompting self-correction (4 min) If errors are extensive, only focus on those related to accuracy (grammar/verb forms) and expression (natural phrasing, e.g., avoiding overly literal translations). E. Read through the corrected version of the dialogue (2 min).			
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Credits & Attributions

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Audio & Script

Audio and script generated with AI assistance (Perplexity AI), based on topic, CEFR level, and content direction specified by the author. Final script and audio pacing reviewed and approved by Carmen Khoury.